98% energy import dependency?

Testing the Pre-Budget Document's energy figure against Eurostat

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

"Eurostat statistics show that Malta's energy import dependency is approximately 98.0 per cent, the highest in the European Union."

Ministry for Finance, Pre-Budget Consultation Document 2027, 30 September 2026. Document launched for the 2027 Budget consultation.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Eurostat: 98.4% in 2024, highest of 27

Version 1.0 · 30 October 2026
Status: no right of reply needed
Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

TL;DR

The Ministry for Finance's Pre-Budget Consultation Document 2027 says: **"Eurostat statistics show that Malta's energy import dependency is approximately 98.0 per cent, the highest in the European Union."** No year is given. We checked both statements against Eurostat.

1. **The level is right.** Eurostat's indicator for Malta was 98.4% in 2024, the latest year, and between 97.0% and 99.0% in every year from 2019 to 2024. The EU-27 figure for 2024 is 57.3%.
2. **The ranking is right.** Malta was highest of the 27 Member States in every year from 2016 to 2024. In 2015 Cyprus was 0.03 points higher. In 2024 the next were Luxembourg (91.0%) and Cyprus (87.7%).
3. **The "98.0" has no stated year.** No year gives exactly 98.0; 2024 gives 98.4. The gap is 0.4 points, and the decimal suggests more precision than the series has.
4. **The indicator is mostly about shipping fuel.** Bunker fuel for international shipping is 68.5% of the energy Eurostat counts for Malta in 2024, and it is all supplied from imports. Domestic use is a smaller figure, which this check does not compute.
5. **Verdict: largely supported (high confidence).** Both statements reproduce; the caveats concern the missing year and what the indicator measures.



98.4%
Malta, 2024 (Eurostat); document says ≈98.0

1st
Rank among 27 Member States in 2024 (next: Luxembourg 91.0%)

57.3%
EU-27 average, 2024

68.5%
Share of Malta's counted energy that is international maritime bunkers, 2024

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
The ministry naming a reference year that gives 98.0 on Eurostat's indicator, or a revision that makes it so.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
A Eurostat revision that puts another Member State above Malta, or a figure for 2025 far from 98%.

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
3 What the data show
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5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
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1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim is in the Ministry for Finance's Pre-Budget Consultation Document 2027, launched on 30 September 2026 [1]. The wording above was read on 26 October 2026 by the project's intake session through a web reader, with the page given as 66 (it may be off by one). The ministry's site returned HTTP 403 to our scripts on 30 October 2026, so we did not re-read the PDF for this report. MaltaToday reported the Finance Minister repeating the figure at the launch [2]; we did not read that article.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
Ministry for Finance, Pre-Budget Consultation Document 2027 [1]	"Eurostat statistics show that Malta's energy import dependency is approximately 98.0 per cent, the highest in the European Union."	Read 26 Oct 2026 (web reader); not re-read 30 Oct (403).	**The claim**
Eurostat, nrg_ind_id [3]	Energy import dependency (net imports over gross available energy), all products, % , by country and year.	Downloaded 30 Oct 2026 (data/cc-140/).	**Primary data**
Eurostat, nrg_bal_c [4]	Malta's imports, exports, gross available energy and bunkers, ktoe.	Downloaded 30 Oct 2026.	**Primary data**

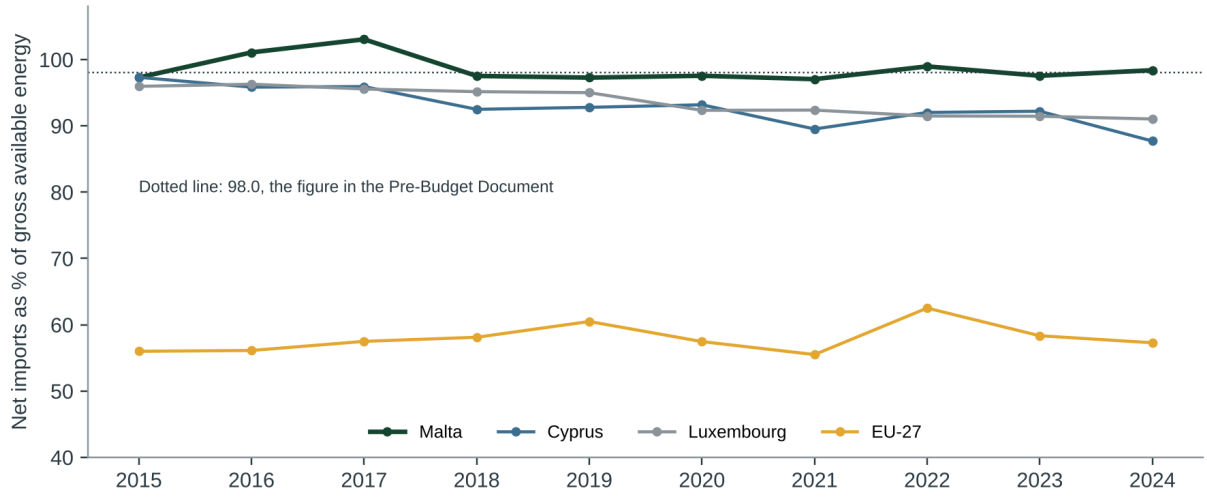
2 Method

Question. Does Eurostat show Malta's energy import dependency at about 98%, and is it the highest in the EU?

Evidence. We downloaded the indicator for all countries, 2015–2024 (*fetch.py*), ranked the 27 Member States by year, and rebuilt Malta's figure from the energy balance as (imports − exports) / gross available energy (*calc.py*; outputs in *data/cc-140/checks.csv*). The rebuilt and published values agree to 0.1 point in every year 2019–2024, so the 98% is the standard Eurostat indicator and not a different calculation. Eurostat's 2025 values were not yet published.

Grades. Official statistics, grade C. No literature is needed for a statistic reported as such. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the data show



Source: Eurostat nrg_ind_id (updated 16 Jul 2026), retrieved 30 Oct 2026. Values above 100% occur when stocks are drawn down.

Figure 1. Energy import dependency, Malta, Cyprus, Luxembourg and the EU-27, 2015–2024 (Eurostat).

Malta's value ranged from 97.0% to 99.0% over 2019–2024 (98.4% in 2024), against 55.5–62.5% for the EU-27. It was above 100% in 2016 and 2017 (101.1% and 103.1%), which Eurostat's method permits when stocks are drawn down. In 2015 Cyprus (97.32%) was marginally above Malta (97.30%); from 2016 to 2024 Malta was first each year.

4 What the figure does not say

The indicator counts gross available energy including international maritime bunkers, the fuel sold to ships. For Malta these were 2,100 ktoe of 3,065 ktoe (68.5%) in 2024 [4]. Because the indicator is net imports over that total, a large share of ships' fuel makes Malta's ratio close to 100% whatever happens to domestic energy use. We did not compute a ratio without bunkers: it would need an assumption about how much of the bunker fuel is imported, and we have no sourced input for that. The statement is accurate as a statement about Eurostat's indicator; it does not tell a reader how much of the energy used by households and businesses in Malta is imported. The document uses the figure in the context of energy subsidies (see CC-095); this check does not assess that argument.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta's energy import dependency is approximately 98.0 per cent	Ministry for Finance [1]	Eurostat: 98.4% in 2024; 97.0–99.0% in 2019–2024. No year is stated; none gives exactly 98.0.	MOSTLY ACCURATE
B. It is the highest in the European Union	Ministry for Finance [1]	Eurostat: first of 27 in every year 2016–2024 (next in 2024: Luxembourg 91.0%).	ACCURATE

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Both statements reproduce from Eurostat; the year is missing and the indicator is dominated by shipping fuel. Confidence: high.

Why. The level and the ranking reproduce. The caveats are minor and do not change the substance. **What this verdict does not say.** It does not say how dependent households and businesses are on imported energy, or whether subsidies are the right response.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the Ministry for Finance: the reference year of the 98.0 figure (future documents could state it).
- ☐ From the maintainer: a downloaded copy of the Pre-Budget PDF, to confirm the sentence and page.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Not needed for this verdict (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026).

7 Limitations

- We could not re-read the PDF on 30 October 2026 (403); the wording rests on the earlier read recorded in the claim record.
- Eurostat’s 2025 values were not available; the ranking after 2024 is untested.
- We did not read the MaltaToday report of the launch.

References

[1] Ministry for Finance (30 Sep 2026). Pre-Budget Consultation Document 2027. https://finance.gov.mt/wp-content/uploads/2026/09/PRE-BUDGET-2027-DOC.pdf

[2] MaltaToday (30 Sep 2026). Report of the Pre-Budget Document launch (seen only as cited in the claim record; not read).

[3] Eurostat. Energy imports dependency (nrg_ind_id), updated 16 Jul 2026, retrieved 30 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/nrg_ind_id/default/table

[4] Eurostat. Complete energy balances (nrg_bal_c), updated 27 Aug 2026, retrieved 30 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/nrg_bal_c/default/table

[5] MiŻien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-140-report/calc.py; data/cc-140/checks.csv.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	30 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Largely supported (high confidence); no right of reply needed.